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SOCIAL



Photo-sharing app
Locket is banking on a
new celebrity-focused
feature to fuel its growth



Locket the photo-sharing app that allows users to share images with friends that are then displayed on their home screens as widgets, wants to stay on top of the social media game, and it's enlisting the help of celebrities. Locket launched in 2022. Locket emerged as a competitor to BeReal, offering a more authentic way to connect with others. The app places a widget on iPhone home screens that updates with the latest pictures added by friends. Users can select up to 20 close friends, creating an intimate space to share unfiltered selfies and updates on their lives.

The app claims to have over 80 million total downloads and more than 9 million daily active users, and its users have shared more than 10 billion photos to date. Notably, the company also shared with TechCrunch that it achieved profitability in 2024, a significant accomplishment given its relatively modest fundraising efforts of just \$12.5 million.

To drive additional growth, Locket has been quietly testing a feature called “Celebrity Lockets” for the past six months, which the app officially announced on Wednesday.

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IMAGE CREDITS: LOCKET

Celebrity Lockets mostly focuses on music artists, letting them engage with fans by sharing details about upcoming shows, new album releases, and other news. Locket has already tested this feature with [Suki Waterhouse](#) and [JVKE](#), with more artists to be announced soon.

To use the feature, celebrities can share a link on their social media platforms, or fans can look them up in the app to add them, and they can then send photos directly to their fans' home screens.

“With posts going straight to fans’ home screens, it offers the kind of immediacy and intimacy that

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other platforms can't replicate, turning passive followers into active participants," founder Matt Moss told TechCrunch.



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Locket allows artists to choose a number of fans to connect with, ranging from 1,000 to 15,000 slots. For instance, Suki has 5,000 fans on the app and has helped Locket attract hundreds of new members. According to the company, 17% of these 5,000 fans were new to Locket.

"Fans feel special knowing they're one of just a few thousand rather than just another follower. This also preserves the same intimacy and brand of Locket as a product today ... We knew our community used Locket to share music with their friends, so being able to also connect with their favorite artists is a natural evolution for the platform," Moss said.

Although Moss says the feedback from testers has been good, it's unclear whether this will help Locket grow its user numbers. BeReal tried something

similar with a feature called “[RealPeople](#),” but the reception wasn’t entirely positive, with [some people](#) saying that they preferred the anti-social media app as a way to escape from celebrities.

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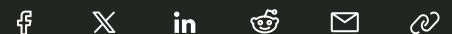
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Lauren covers media, streaming, apps and platforms at TechCrunch.

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The next big social platform is the smartphone's homescreen



The use of notifications and widgets is driving a new set of apps to the top of the App Store

Sarah Perez

9:00 AM PDT · June 16, 2022

BeReal, LiveIn, Locket... what do these new consumer social apps have in common besides a highly ranked position on the App Store's Top Charts? They engage their users through a combination of push notifications and homescreen widgets, instead of forcing people to spend a long time browsing their app, scrolling feeds or watching creator content.

The popularity of this homescreen-based form of social networking is, in part, tied to Apple's move to [launch a widgets platform](#) for the iPhone with the release of iOS 14 in 2020. In doing so, it invited a new ecosystem of apps to emerge.

Initially, this began with apps that allowed users to better personalize their homescreens with widgets and custom app icons that matched their backgrounds, sending apps like [Widgetsmith](#), Brass, Color Widgets and [others to the top of the App Store](#). But over time, developers realized that

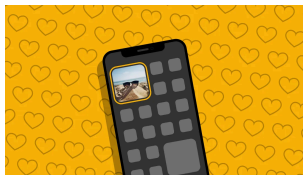
widgets didn't just have to be homescreen decorations — they could, in effect, be an active extension of their own platforms. Their widgets could serve as a tool to engage users in the most personal space on a mobile device: the prime real estate that is the phone's homescreen.

When [Locket](#) first launched in December 2021, this idea was more of a novelty.

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Developer and former Apple WWDC student scholarship winner Matt Moss thought it would be clever to use a widget to send photos to his girlfriend as they embarked on a long-distance relationship. But soon, his friends were clamoring for access to the app he had built as a simple side project.

Locket, an app for sharing photos to friends' homescreens, hits the top of the App Store



A new social app, Locket, popped to the top of the App Store charts in recent days thanks to its clever premise to put live photos from friends in a widget on your iOS homescreen. In other words, it turns Apple's widget system — typically used to showcase information like news, weather, inspirational quotes or ... [Continue reading](#)



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Since then, Locket has expanded from iOS to Android and has now seen a total of 20 million installs to date, according to estimates from app store intelligence firm [Sensor Tower](#). But its popularity has declined a bit as competitors emerged. While Locket was No. 9 in the Social Networking category, as of the time of writing, it was only No. 42 Overall on the U.S. App Store. That rank is largely due to the fact that there are so many other apps now playing in this space and gaining momentum.

For instance, another app called [BeReal](#) had originally arrived in December 2019 — before iPhone’s widgets became broadly available. This social app encourages users to capture a photo within two minutes of receiving a push notification using BeReal’s camera — which takes both a front-facing photo and selfie at the same time. The idea is to give users a way to see what their friends are up to in real time. Before this year, BeReal had seen steady, but not groundbreaking, growth, achieving 1.9 million worldwide installs, per Sensor Tower data. The app is backed by \$30 million in funding, led by a16z, Accel and New Wave.

Then, [in February 2022](#), BeReal tapped into the idea to leverage the homescreen to capture friends’ reactions to users’ posts, with the launch of a feature called “WidgetMojis.” This addition allowed BeReal to display friends’ photos in a live-updating widget on the homescreen as they reacted to users’ BeReal posts, or what BeReal calls RealMojis. By April, the app intelligence firm [Apptopia had reported](#) that BeReal had grown its monthly active users 315% year-to-date and that 65% of its lifetime downloads had occurred this year. That figure has since grown to around 86%, Sensor Tower says, as the app now has a total of 13.9 million lifetime installs.

Introducing WidgetMojis, to keep your friends on your Home Screen when they react to your BeReal. pic.twitter.com/IUQcXrnbW9

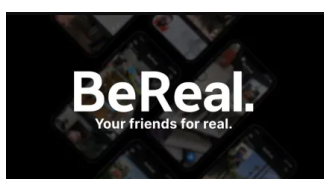
— BeReal. (@BeReal_App) [February 11, 2022](#)

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Over the course of 2022, [BeReal's popularity has skyrocketed](#). This year alone BeReal has gained some 12 million installs, the data further indicates. And, as of the time of writing, BeReal was the No. 10 Overall app on the U.S. App Store, beating out traditional social networking and communication apps like Messenger, Snapchat, Telegram, Discord, Twitter and Pinterest. It was also the No. 3 app in the Social Networking category.

For younger users, BeReal also become part of their cultural lexicon and everyday app rotation. On TikTok, the hashtag [#bereal](#) has more than 390 million views, while variations on the name bring in thousands or millions more.

BeReal: Hype or hit? What to know about the Gen Z photo-sharing app climbing the charts



An app called BeReal, founded by former GoPro employee Alexis Barreyat along with K vin Perreau, launched in December 2019 with its idea of asking users to post an unedited photo once per day after receiving a push notification. Upon receiving the alert, the user has up to 2 minutes to share what they're up to ... [Continue reading](#)



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But BeReal is now only one of many competing in this space. Another vying for a part of this emerging market is the newer addition, [LiveIn](#), which launched in January 2022 after pivoting from a Clubhouse-like app, Livehouse. This homescreen social networking app comes with its own twist. Instead of just sending selfie photos to friends' phones, users can send videos and drawings, as well. Another new feature lets users "duet" photos and videos — taking a cue from the similarly named mashup feature found on TikTok.

The company said in [a press release](#) it reached 4 million monthly active users in the first two months after launch. At the time, the hashtags #liveinapp and #livepic had generated more than 40 million TikTok views. Today, #liveinapp has 279.5 million TikTok views and #livepic has 37.6 million.

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In addition to the casual photo sharing and updated widgets, these new social apps include a photo archive so users can look back at their memories. This serves not only as a way to incentivize users to launch the apps outside of designated photo-taking times, but also as a way to lock in users and keep them from abandoning the platform.

This sort of photo archive isn't a new concept — it's inspired by Facebook and Snapchat's Memories features, but is designed to achieve the same results with a younger crowd.

In fact, these new social apps have taken many of the core concepts more recently popularized by Snapchat — access to real-life friends, private photo sharing, spontaneous and casual photo taking and memories — and have built their own differentiated platforms that tap into the smartphone's notification system and direct homescreen access via widgets.

These three apps are only a handful of a growing number of apps building for social via the phone's homescreen widgets.

Other top downloaded apps include Noteit Widget, which has gained 18.8 million lifetime installs per Sensor Tower data; Loveit: Live Pic & Note Widget (1.4 million installs); Widgetshare (3.1 million installs); Peek (704K installs); WidgetPal (374K installs), SnapWidget (185K installs); Rocket Widget (127K installs); Comet: Live Friends Widget (112K installs); and others.

There are even clones capitalizing on the names of popular brands like the not-so-subtly named app called "LivePic, Locket Photo Widgets" which has managed to pull in 79,000 installs — some of which likely came by way of misdirected App Store searches.

Gen Z's shift to authenticity

Another one of the many things these apps have in common is that they promote sharing real-life photos that don't involve heavy editing, filters or AR effects — features Snapchat and Instagram had become known for. This speaks to a broader shift that's helping fuel this trend: the [end of the Instagram aesthetic](#) and the [increased desire for authenticity](#) on social media.

We already saw hints of this emerging with the launches of other newcomer social photo apps like [Dispo](#) or [Poparazzi](#), both of which focused on uncurated photostreams — the latter, where photos were snapped and posted by the user's friends, not users themselves. There were also the apps that aimed at photographers abandoned by Instagram — like [Glass](#), or [Herd Social](#), which had positioned themselves as being “anti-Instagram” apps.

This group of photo apps promoted their defiance of Big Tech with its manufactured algorithms, the overabundance of features and the hyper-competitiveness that now sees mainstream social networks chasing TikTok with short videos, not to mention their collective drive to incorporate all sorts of other activity — like e-commerce, creator subscriptions, virtual tipping, NFTs and more. When it's not trying to be an online mall, Instagram is trying to clone TikTok, for example. Snapchat is hosting creator content and now [wants users to shop](#) using AR.

Poparazzi hits 5M+ downloads a year after launch, confirms its \$15M Series A



Poparazzi, the anti-Instagram social app that hit the top of the App Store last year, is today, for the first time, detailing the growth stats for its business, its future plans and its previously unconfirmed Benchmark-led Series A round. The L.A.-area startup now reports its iOS-only has seen over 5 million installs in its first ... [Continue reading](#)



Meanwhile, younger users — the key demographic that uses social apps — seemed to have actually just wanted simpler apps that focused on what they think social networking should be about: their friends.

It's funny that it's come to this. The “social graph” was once [the holy grail](#) of consumer social platforms — to know who someone was connected to in

real life was perceived as valuable data. For one thing, it meant you could lock users into a walled garden they wouldn't want to leave because their friends were all there, too. And making this social graph inaccessible to competitors meant every new network had to start from scratch. But these days, mainstream social networks are more heavily focused on connecting

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Yubo could be the next big social app as it raises \$47.5 million



French startup Yubo is the biggest social media app you've never heard of — unless you're a teen. With a focus on young people under 25, the company has managed to attract 40 million users. A fraction of them hang out every day in live-streaming rooms, meet new people and spend money for more features. ... [Continue reading](#)



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The trend is similarly impacting dating, leading to Match's [biggest-ever acquisition of Hyperconnect](#) for \$1.73 billion, which had been building “social discovery” apps that weren't designed specifically for romantic connections. And Bumble today is [beefing up its “BFF” feature](#) as younger people are shifting their interest to friend-finding apps.

But this shift in social isn't without concerns. Though mainstream social apps are now being held accountable regarding their user protections, newer social apps are flying under the radar. Parents haven't heard of these new apps and don't know to monitor or restrict them as a result. The same goes for lawmakers and regulators, too, who have their eyes affixed solely on tech giants. And as reports have shown, [the apps' privacy protections and](#)

[policies, in some cases, are fairly weak](#). This is particularly concerning given that many are marketed toward and used by tweens and younger teens, who may inadvertently post to global, public feeds instead of to friends, post inappropriate content or become the victims of cyberbullying.

But the apps' freewheeling nature isn't the only reason why homescreen social networking is having a moment. Beyond those mentioned above, there are many other factors at play here — including the apps' clever use of TikTok to drive downloads, influencer marketing and [college ambassador programs](#) to spread the word about new apps more “organically.” There's also the continuous background noise related to social networking's ill effects that Gen Z is aware of, even if only marginally. [Data scandals](#), high-profile leaks and [whistleblowing](#), [Congressional hearings](#), regulatory inquiries and the resulting [media coverage](#) have helped fuel consumer demand for apps that weren't created by today's dominant players.

The market's readiness for this type of networking is demonstrated by how well these “homescreen social” apps are currently doing. They're dominating the Social Networking charts and are staking their position in the Overall Top Charts. While, longer-term, they could end up being another flash in the pan the way [location-based social networking apps were in the 2010s](#), there's a sense that some Gen Z users no longer consider these apps experimental.

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And while TikTok is certainly a viable threat in terms of capturing the valuable — and profitable — connection between users and creators, users' social graphs are still up for grabs. In fact, [many among](#) Gen Z [don't want to share](#) their real-world relationships with TikTok, they've said in videos posted to the platform. They appreciate that TikTok is a network that's about creativity and individualized interests, not their real-world connections.

[@420koreabo](#)no every time damn stop asking 🎵 [ITSJULYSKI – JULYSKI](#)

TikTok has [realized](#) this too, and understands the risk it poses for its own business. It even got so pushy about acquiring users' address books that it destroyed its own Discover page [in favor of a Friends page](#) in hopes of capturing that data.

If the trend continues, it could impact other mainstream social networks, which have largely ignored this new avenue to gain users and haven't adopted the "live pics from friends" widget format, either.

With the social graph filtering to smaller, simpler homescreen social networking apps, there also now comes the potential to build a different kind of social network that could be monetized in new ways beyond ads. These apps could roll out premium features, a subscription service, direct payment and more. But that future is still in question, as it remains to be seen whether homescreen social networking apps have long-term staying power among the historically fickle younger crowd who have adopted them.

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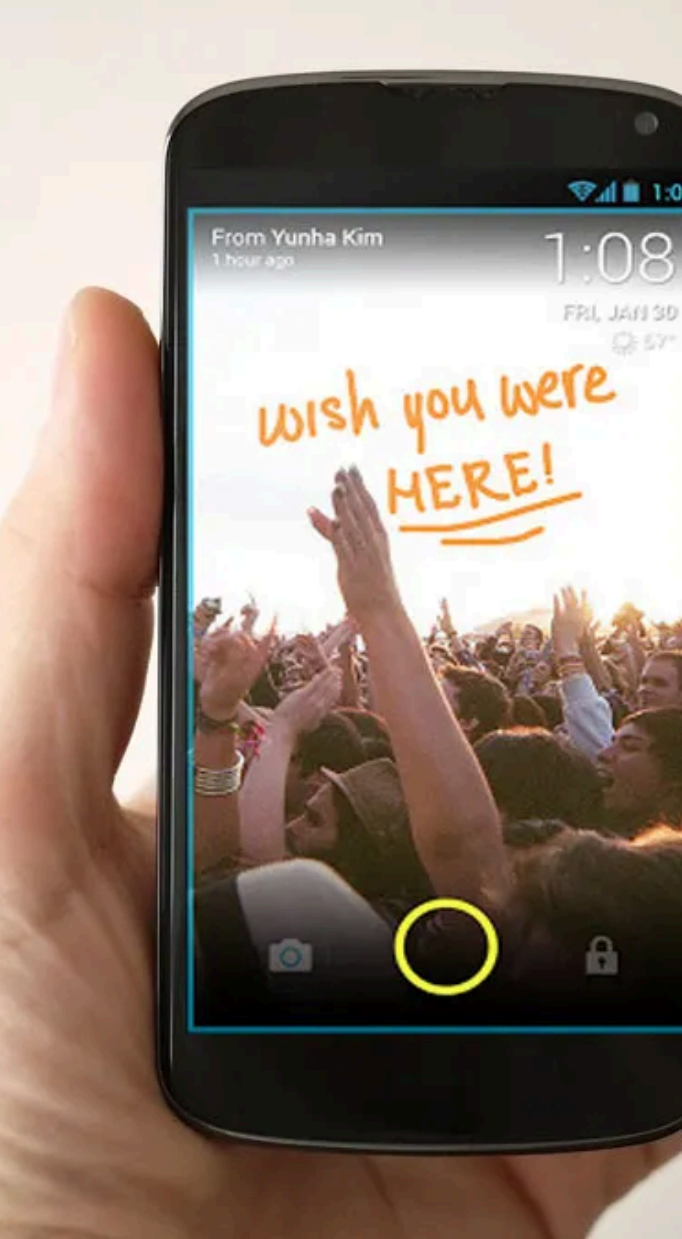
Sarah Perez

Consumer News Editor | [X](#) [🦋](#) [@](#) [in](#)

Sarah has worked as a reporter for TechCrunch since August 2011. She joined the company after having previously spent over three years at ReadWriteWeb. Prior to her work as a reporter, Sarah worked in I.T....

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ScreenPop, Backed By \$3.2 Million, Lets You Message Friends From Your Phone's Lockscreen

Sarah Perez — 7:09 AM PST · February 10, 2015

[Locket](#), the makers of a mobile application that brings personalized news and other stories to your Android phone's lockscreen is out today with a new lockscreen-based messaging application called [ScreenPop](#). The new app, which grew to 15,000 users during two months of beta testing, is designed to allow anyone to send photos, doodles, emoji and more after just a quick swipe on their phone's screen.

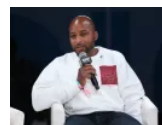
The startup is also announcing the close of their \$3.2 million seed round, which included investment from Tyra Banks, Turner Broadcasting, Great Oaks and various N.Y.-area angel investors.

Some portion of that fundraiser [was previously announced](#), but Locket didn't close on the round until late 2014, explains CEO Yunha Kim.

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Actionable advice from top investors
at TechCrunch Disrupt 2025

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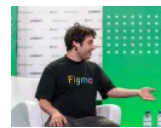
The Locket app, by way of background, began its life as a utility that put ads on Android lockscreens. Users who interacted with those ads would then earn small amounts of money every time they unlocked their phone. But the app later transitioned away from the pay-per-swipe business model to instead allow users to customize the content they received on their lockscreens, to include things like breaking news, funny pictures, or inspiring stories, for example.

Following this change, the Locket app was selected as one of the “best apps” of 2014, and has now reached around a million downloads.



The new release of ScreenPop is based on the same technology the company already developed for Locket, but it's being utilized to appeal to a

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younger demographic. While Locket users are generally in their late 20's to early 30's, the majority of ScreenPop users are teens and young adults.

ScreenPop, the company tells us, was originally an idea the team had built at a hackathon and began to use internally. Later, they put the app into beta testing on the Google Play store under a different name to see how users would respond. The app ended up seeing good growth metrics, as users would download the app, and then invite around four friends to join them, on average. And they would send around four photos to friends per day using ScreenPop, too.



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The overall idea with ScreenPop is to make it easier to communicate with friends, says Kim. “We were seeing this trend in photo sharing,” she says, referencing how apps have evolved to simplify the process of photo-sharing – going from Facebook’s still more cumbersome process to Instagram’s photos, and then Snapchat, whose app takes you

directly to a camera. “By taking off the lockscreen barrier, it’s allowing people to actually send more photos. And because [the photo] goes away after you unlock the phone, people are sending more photos than we thought they would,” she adds.

As noted above, the app grew to 15,000 users during beta trials, and those users are now being prompted to transition to the new app, ScreenPop through a lockscreen notification. Already, several thousand have made the move, according to Google Play store data.

With the close of the additional round, the now 8-person team (who relocated to San Francisco from New York) is starting to think about how to port the experience to iOS. That will be a little more challenging since iOS doesn’t let you create interactive lockscreens. But Kim says the plan is to take advantage of iOS 8’s new notification system in some way, while also creating an experience that’s similarly focused on allowing users to quickly send photos and other messages.

ScreenPop for Android is [a free download here on Google Play](#).

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